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EXTERNAL AFFAIRS MINISTER S. Jaishankar is quick on the uptake and likes to give as good as he gets. When Congress leader Rahul Gandhi accused Indian diplomats of being arrogant at a conference in London, Jaishankar in a tweet retorted, "Yes, they counter the arguments of others. No, it's not called Arrogance. It is called Confidence. And it is called defending National Interest." Then, at a press conference in Washington D.C. where his American counterpart was present, asked why India was importing oil from Russia after it invaded Ukraine, Jaishankar pointed out, "You need to focus on Europe. Probably India's purchase of oil for the month from Russia would be less than what Europe does in an afternoon."

Defending India's national interests and advancing them while ensuring the global good in a turbulent international arena has been the hallmark of the ministry of external affairs (MEA) in the third year of Modi 2.0. When successive waves of Covid ravaged India, the MEA employed what the then foreign secretary Harsh Shringla described as "medical diplomacy". That involved ensuring vital medicines and vaccines manufactured in India to combat Covid were supplied to needy countries by expediting the export process, apart from facilitating technical collaborations with key manufacturers and suppliers to meet India's needs. The MEA also had to get into the rescue act by evacuating Indian nationals both during the Taliban takeover of Afghanistan last year and during the Russian invasion of Ukraine in February, when over 20,000 students were stranded in the warzone.

When it comes to pure diplomacy, the MEA could pat itself on the back for ensuring that there were no hiccups in India's relations with the US when the transition from Donald Trump to Joe Biden happened. Most importantly, Biden convened the first important in-person summit of the Quadrilateral Dialogue or Quad that brought leaders of US, Japan, India and Australia together on a single stage in Washington D.C. in September last year. It sent a powerful message that a new bulwark was being built against a belligerent China. Last week, the four Quad nations took the next big step by launching the Indo-Pacific Economic Forum along with nine other Asia Pacific countries that contribute 40 per cent to global GDP. While it is far from a trade pact, the process of forming an alternative economic grouping to challenge China's dominance in the region has begun. As important was the signing of two important trade agreements with Australia and the UAE, signalling India's intent to expand its trade footprint, with a handful of similar trade pacts on the anvil.

While India's relations with China have been at a low ebb after Beijing's border intrusions in 2020, there were 15 rounds of negotiations between the two countries to restore status quo at the border, which made some progress. India had more success with its other neighbours. The Sri Lankans, for instance, appreciated India's timely financial aid during the ongoing political and economic crisis. Relations in Nepal are back on track, as they are in the Maldives as well. The stalemate with Pakistan continues, as India waits for the new ruling dispensation to survive the political and economic landmines it faces. On the international stage, India acquitted itself well when it assumed the presidency of the Security Council and PM Narendra Modi chaired a session that brought an important resolution to enhance maritime security.

As they embark on their fourth year, Modi and his foreign affairs team confront an uncertain world. With the Russia-Ukraine war disrupting energy and commodities supply, inflation has risen dangerously, not to mention global food shortages and a possible global recession. For India, it is important to not only build its supply chain resilience, but the crisis also provides it an opportunity to lay the foundation to become a viable economic alternative to China. So, the country needs to further strengthen its partnerships with major powers to insulate against the risks. Successfully navigating the choppy international waters while enhancing its national interests will continue to be the thrust of its foreign policy for the next two years. It will need all of Jaishankar's diplomatic dexterity to keep so many balls in the air without dropping any of them. ■

WHAT'S DONE

- Two in-person Quad Summits held to contain China
- Improved relations with Sri Lanka, Nepal, Maldives
- Rescued stranded Indians from Afghanistan, Ukraine
- Kept up ties with Russia despite western pressure
- Maintained continuity of good relations with the US

CHALLENGES AHEAD

- Prepare agenda for G 20 when India assumes presidency in December
- Navigate emerging world order in the wake of Russia-Ukraine war, the pandemic
- Build linkages with major powers to enhance supply chain resilience
- Negotiate with China and restore status quo on LAC
- Continue to keep the US focused on the Indo-Pacific